

The Golden Path

Ideal Customer Journey — All Quality Badges Mobile Badge Designer

Prepared by: Henry | Date: August 6, 2026 | Companion to the automated QA suite (badge-qa) — the persona tests in customer-personas.spec.js exercise real human behavior against this same ideal.

The order used as the reference case

N badges, each with Name + Title (2 lines), magnetic backing.

Golden path — same shape/style across all N badges

- 1 Land on the product page → tool opens directly at "Pick a Shape." No dead space above it.
- 2 Pick shape — once.
- 3 Pick color/style — once.
- 4 Icon step: nothing to tap. "No icon" is the default — the customer only interacts with this step if they actively want an icon.
- 5 Text step: switch to bulk mode, paste Name,Title for all N badges in one paste.
- 6 Backing: pick Magnetic — once, applied to the whole batch.
- 7 Review proof (all N badges shown at once) → Confirm and Add to Cart.
- 8 Checkout.

That's 6 decisions, regardless of whether N is 2 or 50. This is the benchmark the tool should be measured against — the "Efficient Emma" persona test exercises exactly this path.

This is the order shape that matters most: most customers order one badge style/shape per order (a team, a department, an event), not a mix of different shapes in a single order. The bulk CSV path already serves this well — varying Name and Title per row while everything else (shape, color, icon, backing) is set once for the whole batch.

How this connects to the automated tests

Golden path step	Covered by
Steps 1–4 friction (labels, icon default, scroll)	Issues 16, 17, 18 (Round 3 findings)
Step 5 bulk text entry	scenario-blue-bulk10-white-magnetic and other named scenarios
Real human behavior around this path	tests/customer-personas.spec.js

The customer personas, and what each one is really checking

Persona	Simulates	What it's really testing
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Efficient Emma	The golden path, zero mistakes	Whether the ideal path is actually as smooth as it should be
Clumsy Carl	Changing an earlier choice after later steps are already filled in	Stale state — does correcting something early properly update everything downstream?
Backtracking Betty	Reaching the proof step, going back to edit, re-confirming	Whether the FINAL edited version reaches the cart, or an edit can get silently dropped
Interrupted Ian	Closing the tab mid-design and mid-cart, reopening later	Documents actual behavior for a common real pattern — walking away, coming back
Returning Rachel	Pays as a guest, comes back days later for her order	Whether a guest customer has any real path back to her order history

Persona tests are intentionally **behavioral**, not combinatorial — a different lens than the pairwise/scenario suites, and both are needed. Pairwise finds “these two options break together.” Personas find “a real person doing something reasonable but imperfect breaks the tool.”

Journey narratives — the most likely step-by-step path for each persona

The concrete, moment-by-moment path each persona is most likely to actually take, written out to make the “why” behind each test obvious at a glance.

1. Efficient Emma — the golden path

- 1 Lands on the badge designer, "Pick a Shape" already in view
- 2 Taps a shape once, taps a color once
- 3 Sees the icon step, doesn't want one, moves straight past it (relies on "No" being the default)
- 4 Opens "Add Your Text," switches to bulk mode, pastes 10 rows of Name, Title in one paste
- 5 Picks "Magnetic" for backing
- 6 Reviews the proof (all 10 badges shown), ticks the confirmation box, taps Confirm and Add to Cart
- 7 Goes to cart, taps Checkout, completes payment

Total friction points: zero, ideally. This is the benchmark — if even Emma hits a snag, it's a tool problem, not a “confused customer” problem.

2. Clumsy Carl — corrects himself mid-flow

- 1 Picks a shape, picks white background (his first instinct)
- 2 Picks the cross icon
- 3 Types his name and title
- 4 Looks at the preview, decides he actually wants it on black — goes back and changes the background AFTER the icon and text are already set
- 5 Glances at the preview again to confirm the icon didn't vanish (this is exactly the black-background contrast bug found in manual testing)
- 6 Picks a backing, reviews the proof
- 7 Adds to cart

Most realistic risk point: step 5 — if the icon disappears and Carl doesn't catch it, he could order a badge with an invisible icon, or get frustrated at a preview that "looks wrong" without understanding why and abandon.

3. Backtracking Betty — catches a mistake late

- 1 Completes a full design efficiently, same as Emma
- 2 "Reviews your proof," actually reads it carefully (unlike Emma, who might just tick and go)
- 3 Spots a typo or wrong title
- 4 Taps "Back to Edit" (or whatever it's currently labeled)
- 5 Fixes the text
- 6 Has to re-reach the proof screen and re-confirm
- 7 Adds to cart

Most realistic risk point: steps 6–7 — this is exactly where the flash-to-blank-Step-1 bug lives. Betty's mental model at this moment is "I fixed my mistake," so if the transition looks like it wiped her design, that's a genuine trust-breaking moment, not just a visual glitch.

4. Interrupted Ian — walks away mid-design

- 1 Starts a design on his phone during a work break — picks a shape, a color, starts typing a name
- 2 Gets pulled into a meeting, closes the browser tab without finishing
- 3 Comes back that evening, opens the site again
- 4 Outcome is genuinely unpredictable without checking — either the tool remembers nothing and Ian starts over, or it partially restores his progress

Most realistic behavior: most people don't remember exactly what they picked before — if the tool starts fresh, most Ians shrug and redo it in under a minute. If it "remembers" but gets it subtly wrong, that's worse than remembering nothing, since Ian might not double check and order something he didn't mean to.

5. Returning Rachel — needs her order after she's already paid

- 1 Completes an order and pays, same as Emma
- 2 Closes the tab
- 3 A week later, wants to check her order status or reorder the same badge for a new hire
- 4 Comes back to the site — this is where "Sign in on the storefront to save and reorder in one click" either pays off, or Rachel realizes she never created an account and has no easy way to find her past order

Most realistic risk point: step 4 — if Rachel didn't sign in originally, this is a real drop-off point for repeat business. Worth checking whether the tool actively encourages account creation BEFORE checkout (when there's a concrete incentive) rather than treating it as an afterthought.

See the badge-qa test suite ([customer-personas.spec.js](#)) for the automated implementation of all five journeys, run across desktop Chrome/Firefox/Safari and emulated mobile Chrome/Safari.